A DEADLY SURGE

MARCH 2	Panchayat member killed at Srandoo village of Kulgam
MARCH 10	Sarpanch killed at Khonmoh, Srinagar
MARCH 11	Sarpanch killed at Adoora village of Kulgam
MARCH 12	CRPF jawan killed at his home in Shopian
MARCH 19	Non-local carpenter shot and injured in Aripal area of Pulwama
MARCH 21	Non-local street vendor shot and injured at Gangoo village of Pulwama
APRIL 3	Two non-locals shot and injured at Lassipora, Pulwama
APRIL 4	Kashmiri Pandit shot and injured in Shopian
APRIL 7	Non-local shot and injured at Yader village of Pulwama
APRIL 13	Kashmiri Rajput man killed at Kakran village in Kulgam
APRIL 15	Sarpanch killed at Pattan village of Baramulla

secured enclaves that have come up in parts of the Valley to encourage Pandits to return. Abandoning their native homes is, of course, not easy for the Rajputs of Kakran: they had chosen to continue here, and build their lives, despite decades of insurgency. "We stayed due to the affection of our Muslim neighbours. But now we feel threatened," says Kuljeet Singh. "And where will we go? Even if we sell the entire property, we wouldn't be able to buy a house in Jammu or another city."

By this March, according to data compiled by the Union ministry of home affairs, 14 Hindus, including Pandits, had been killed since the abrogation of Article 370 on August 5, 2019. Besides minorities, non-local migrant workers and elected members of panchayats are also in the crosshairs of militants. The past two years saw 38 targeted attacks, including 12 this year. The attacks have triggered a wave of fear among migrant workers who recently arrived in the Valley. "My parents, wife and children have been calling me several times a day since hearing of the attacks. They are worried about my well-being and want me to return home," says Sanjay Kumar, a 38-year-old mason from Bihar who has been coming to Srinagar for work every year since 2003. Annually, an estimated 1 million workers come to the Valley from states such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and West Bengal to earn a living as masons, carpenters, vendors, embroiderers etc.

NEW MILITANT OUTFITS ARE TARGETING LOCAL HINDUS, MIGRANT WORKERS AND PANCHAYAT MEMBERS

It is widely believed that The Resistance Front (TRF)—a new outfit that emerged on the scene after August 2019 and which the police describe as an offshoot of the Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT)—is responsible for most of the attacks on minorities and migrants. These attacks are said to be in response to the abrogation of Article 35A, which had empowered the J&K legislature to define the state's permanent residents and give them rights denied to others. DGP Dilbagh Singh, however, believes successful operations such as the killing of two Pakistani LeT militants within a week after they attacked CRPF personnel in Srinagar has frustrated terror outfits. "That is why they are assigning soft targets to new recruits," he says.

Many like former deputy chief minister and BJP leader Nirmal Singh see the targeted attacks as part of the agenda of 'Gazwa-e-Hind', a term Pakistani militants use to describe a "holy war to conquer India". "Communal tension during Ramnavami (in parts of India) was orchestrated by some elements and the same is happening in Kashmir (to drive out Hindus), but people won't allow this to succeed," says Singh. Another motive, adds the BJP leader, is to disrupt the Centre's efforts to bring in investors to set up industries in the region. According to the Union home ministry, the J&K government has received investment proposals worth Rs 51,000 crore so far, and plans are afoot for the first J&K Global Investors' Summit.

Amid the spurt in targeted killings, the little-known Lashkar-e-Islam recently sent a threatening letter to the Veerwan Pandit camp in Baramulla, setting off panic among Hindus in the Valley. Comparing the current situation with that of the '90s when the community was "backstabbed and forced to leave Kashmir by creating a hostile environment", Kashmiri Pandit Sangharsh Samiti president Sanjay Tickoo says similar conditions are being created again. "Though the people responsible were small in number, the collective silence of others created a trust deficit between communities that continues. In 1990, the hit lists were circulated from mosques; now, it's done through the internet. But the mentality that minorities have to face remains the same." The ghosts have returned to haunt them. ■